

DAY 4: REPLACE BIG-TICKET ITEMS FOR LESS

When Joseph and I moved into our new home last year, we envisioned a wrought iron patio set on the lanai, a cozy king bed for the master bedroom, and the perfect arrangement of couches, loveseats, and chairs to entertain guests. The only problem was, after the down payment, we didn't have any extra money in the budget to make any of those purchases. It was overwhelming to decide what to save for and how to start!

You might think a new furniture set, mattress, large appliances, and electronics shouldn't be considered a monthly expense; however, they do creep into our budgets at various times throughout the year. Whether an item is old and needs replacing, or you finally have enough money saved up to splurge on something shiny and new, you have to be prepared for these one-time expenses just as much as your monthly ones. A little bit of research in the beginning, as well as close attention to shifting prices, will help you make the best possible purchase.

Whenever I feel overwhelmed by all the things I need or want to buy, I make a Household Wish List. It doesn't matter whether you have the money to buy everything on that list right now—that's why it's called a wish list! This short exercise transfers all your wants and needs from brain to paper, so you can see everything you'd like to buy in one glance.

Once you have your list, pull out a clean sheet of paper and write down each item in the order you want (or need) to purchase it. If you have a spouse, schedule a date night at home and talk over this list together, then label accordingly. For structure to help fill in those blanks, you can download a Household Wish List at

CreativeSavingsBlog.com/ExpenseResources

The items you write down may or may not be purchases you need to make right away, so depending on the timetable, you have some time to find *exactly* what you want—which is usually how I prefer to shop anyway!